

Michigan State - 2026 Preseason Primer

2026 COLLEGE FOOTBALL PRESEASON PRIMER | BIG TEN

Legend: trend - ● ↑ better · ● ↔ similar · ● ↓ worse · **assessment** - ● strong/positive · ● average/mixed/uncertain · ● weak/negative · ◆ new player or coach

1. 60-Second Briefing

Initial conclusions

Question	Answer
How good?	Lower-middle Power 4 profile with a credible veteran-QB/run-game structure.
Preseason consensus	AP unranked (0 votes) · SP+ No. 62
Returning production	47% (No. 95) overall · Off. 50% (No. 81) · Def. 45% (No. 93)
Primer power rating	+2.0 points vs. average FBS
Expected season	4.6 wins · most likely 5-7
Net vs. 2025	● ↔ Similar overall - Better-defined QB/run-game structure is offset by heavy WR, OL, front-seven, secondary and specialist turnover.
Confidence	Medium-low

2026 identity: OC Nick Sheridan builds around QB Alessio Milivojevic, RB Cam Edwards and a still-forming veteran OL, using foundational formations and inside zone before adapting by matchup.

Bottom line: Michigan State has enough QB, RB and LB structure to compete, but SP+ SOS No. 22 and low continuity make 5-7 safer than a full rebound call.

Beats expectations if: QB Alessio Milivojevic is steady, RB Cam Edwards upgrades the run game, the OL settles, and DC Joe Rossi's transfers/injury returns create more havoc.

Disappoints if: OL/WR competitions remain unstable, the rebuilt secondary repeats 2025 efficiency problems, and the late schedule exposes the low-continuity roster.

Five things to remember

- 1 ★ **QB Alessio Milivojevic:** QB Alessio Milivojevic is the established first-team quarterback after starting the final four games of 2025; QB Cam Fancher gives Michigan State unusually experienced backup depth.
- 2 ★ **RB Cam Edwards:** RB Cam Edwards arrives after 1,240 rushing yards and 15 touchdowns at UConn and carries both Maxwell and Doak Walker recognition.
- 3 **Linebackers:** LB Jordan Hall is the defensive centerpiece, but the broader roster returns only 47% of production and depends heavily on transfers across both sides.
- 4 **2025 baseline:** The 2025 defense prevented explosives reasonably well (No. 58) but allowed efficient drives (No. 115 success rate) and created little havoc (No. 113).
- 5 **Schedule pressure:** SP+ SOS is No. 22, and after the late-October bye Michigan State travels to Michigan, hosts Washington and then hosts Oregon in three consecutive games.

2. 2025 in Context

Traditional Stats

Measure	2025	Assessment
Record	4-8 (1-8 Big Ten)	● Poor
Scoring	24.6 PPG	● Below average
Total offense	345.5 YPG	● Below average
Rush offense	122.8 YPG · 3.8 YPC	● Poor
Pass efficiency	7.07 YPA · 20 TD / 6 INT	● Average / mixed
Third downs	34.8%	● Poor
Scoring defense	29.9 PPG allowed	● Below average
Total defense	378.7 YPG allowed	● Average / mixed
Rush defense	147.3 YPG · 4.5 YPC	● Average / mixed
Pass defense	231.3 YPG · 7.56 YPA · 23 TD allowed	● Poor

The offense was below average overall, especially rushing (No. 110) and third down (No. 110), although pass efficiency was a more respectable No. 61. The defense was less poor in total yardage (No. 72) than in scoring (No. 104) and pass efficiency (No. 117).

Advanced Stats

Measure	2025	Assessment
Opp.-adjusted offense	-0.74 · No. 68	● Average / mixed
Off. EPA/play	-0.033 · No. 79	● Average / mixed
Off. success rate	41.6% · No. 85	● Average / mixed
Off. explosive-play rate	10.8% · No. 102	● Below average
Havoc allowed	18.1% · No. 120	● Poor
Opp.-adjusted defense	-1.17 · No. 75	● Average / mixed
Def. EPA/play allowed	+0.007 · No. 66	● Average / mixed
Def. success rate allowed	44.9% · No. 115	● Poor
Def. explosive-play rate allowed	11.7% · No. 58	● Average / mixed
Havoc created	13.1% · No. 113	● Poor

Advanced-stat read: Michigan State was closer to average by offensive adjustment/EPA than its raw results suggest, but disruption was the major weakness: No. 120 havoc allowed, No. 113 havoc created and No. 115 defensive success rate.

EPA and success rate use CFB Graphs regular-season data. Explosive rate uses regular-season non-garbage-time cfbfastR plays; explosive = 10+ yd rush or 20+ yd pass. Havoc = TFL + forced fumbles + passes defended per play. Lower is better for defensive rates and offensive havoc allowed.

3. Coaching

Role	2026 status	Quick impact
HC	◆ Pat Fitzgerald - new external head coach	● ↔ Program reset without an assumed performance jump
OC / play-caller	◆ Nick Sheridan - from Alabama	● ↑ Clear caller and defined foundational system give the offense structure
DC	Joe Rossi - returning	● ↔ Defensive continuity helps amid extensive roster turnover

4. Key Roster Movement

Offense

In	From	Expected effect
◆ RB Cam Edwards	UConn	● ↑ Proven 1,240-yard, 15-TD runner and the clearest offensive upgrade.
◆ QB Cam Fancher	UCF	● ↔ Adds 28 career starts as experienced depth behind QB Alessio Milivojevic.
◆ OL Ben Murawski	UConn	● ↑ Twelve-start LT transfer with Outland recognition joins the first-unit competition.
◆ OL Trent Fraley	North Dakota State	● ↔ Thirteen-start center adds experienced OL competition.

Out	To	Loss
WR Nick Marsh	Indiana	● ↓ Major 2025 receiving production departs.
WR Omari Kelly	NFL (Chicago), undrafted free agent	● ↓ Material 2025 WR departs for an NFL opportunity.
TE Jack Velling	NFL (Atlanta), undrafted free agent	● ↓ Meaningful TE production departs for an NFL opportunity.
C Matt Gulbin	NFL (Washington), Round 6, No. 209	● ↓ Starting center leaves as a sixth-round draft pick.
OT Stanton Ramil	Auburn	● ↓ Significant tackle loss adds to the open best-five competition.

Offensive net: ● ↔ **Similar to modestly better in structure;** QB Alessio Milivojevic and RB Cam Edwards raise the floor, but WR/TE/OL continuity is low.

Defense

In	From	Expected effect
◆ EDGE Kenny Soares Jr.	NC State	● ↑ Productive transfer projected for a major edge role.
◆ LB Dion Crawford	Buffalo	● ↔ Adds 81 tackles of 2025 production to the LB competition.
◆ LB Cam Stodghill	Albany	● ↔ Provides 65 tackles in seven games and rotation competition.
◆ CB Charles Brantley	Miami	● ↔ Veteran transfer joins a rebuilt first-unit CB competition.

Out	To	Loss
LB Darius Snow	Texas	● ↓ Experienced LB production departs.
DT Alex VanSumeren	USC	● ↓ Material interior production departs.
DL Jalen Thompson	Arizona State	● ↓ Meaningful DL loss increases reliance on transfers and returners.
DL Quindarius Dunnigan	NFL (Jacksonville), undrafted free agent	● ↓ Significant 2025 defender departs for an NFL opportunity.
S Malik Spencer	NFL (Washington), undrafted free agent	● ↓ Substantial 2025 safety departs for an NFL opportunity.

Defensive net: ● ↔ **Similar overall,** with injury-return upside but substantial front and secondary turnover.

5. How They Play

Phase	Identity	What works	Main vulnerability
Offense	OC Nick Sheridan uses 2x2/3x1 and inside-zone foundations with an opponent-specific menu.	QB Alessio Milivojevic plus RB Cam Edwards and veteran RB depth.	Unsettled WR/OL order and No. 120 havoc allowed in 2025.
Defense	DC Joe Rossi emphasizes effort, swarm and physicality in a returning system.	LB Jordan Hall, DL Ben Roberts and S Nikai Martinez lead a transfer-supported core.	Low 2025 havoc and a rebuilt secondary.
Special teams	Dedicated coordinator with turnover at punter and an open kicker job.	P Rhys Dakin is the high-confidence punter projection.	SP+ No. 105 and an unsettled kicker.

6. Unit Grades

Unit	Grade	vs. 2025	Confidence	Why
QB	● B-	● ↑	Medium-high	QB Alessio Milivojevic owns the job after four 2025 starts; QB Cam Fancher adds experienced depth.
RB	● B	● ↑	Medium	RB Cam Edwards brings 1,240 yards, 15 TDs and proven lead-back production.
WR	● C+	● ↓	Low	WR Chrishon McCray returns, but major WR departures leave a transfer-heavy order unsettled.
TE	● C+	● ↓	Medium-low	TE Jack Velling departs; TE Jack Gulker brings production but no proven Big Ten role.
OL	● B-	● ↔	Medium-low	Returning experience plus transfer OL depth helps, but the best five remains unsettled.
DL/Edge	● C+	● ↔	Medium-low	DL Ben Roberts returns while EDGE Kenny Soares Jr. adds production to a reworked front.
LB	● B-	● ↔	Medium	LB Jordan Hall anchors a deeper transfer-supported group.
Secondary	● C+	● ↔	Low	S Nikai Martinez returns, but multiple veterans depart and the rebuilt group must improve 2025 pass efficiency.
Special teams	● C	● ↓	Medium-low	P Rhys Dakin replaces drafted P Ryan Eckley; kicker remains open and SP+ ranks No. 105.
Coaching	● B-	● ↔	Medium-low	HC Pat Fitzgerald and OC Nick Sheridan reset the offense while DC Joe Rossi preserves continuity.
Overall	● C+	● ↔	Medium-low	Below-average but functional Power 4 quality, with too many unsettled high-leverage roles for a B-range grade.

7. Players to Know

Recognition status: official conference honors and major award watchlists through Aug. 22, 2026.

Player	Pos.	Evaluation	Preseason recognition	Why he matters
Alessio Milivojevic	QB	● Adequate Power 4 starter projection	-	Established first-team QB and stabilizer for the new offense.
◆ Cam Edwards (TR: UConn)	RB	● High-end conference starter projection	Doak Walker · Maxwell	Proven 1,240-yard, 15-TD newcomer with upgrade potential.
Jordan Hall	LB	● High-end conference starter / defensive centerpiece	Bednarik · Butkus	Returns after 88 tackles and all 12 starts.
Chrishon McCray	WR	● Returning lead receiver	-	Clearest returning pass-game anchor in a transfer-heavy room.
◆ Ben Murawski (TR: UConn)	OL	● Experienced first-unit transfer / tackle candidate	Outland	Twelve LT starts make him a visible best-five contender.

Player	Pos.	Evaluation	Preseason recognition	Why he matters
Ben Roberts	DL	● Returning interior leader / health return	-	Important returning leader after an injury-limited 2025.
◆ Kenny Soares Jr. (TR: NC State)	EDGE	● Projected major edge transfer	-	Productive addition to a defense needing more havoc.
Nikai Martinez	S	● Returning starting-safety projection / health return	-	One of the few continuity pieces in a rebuilt secondary.

8. Schedule

Item	Assessment
Overall	Hard; the first two home games create a runway, but the Big Ten schedule offers few easy margins and the November Michigan/Washington/Oregon run is severe.
Difficulty	● 8/10 · Hard · SP+ SOS No. 22
Hardest stretch	at Michigan -> Washington -> Oregon
Swing games	Nebraska, at Wisconsin, Northwestern, at UCLA, at Rutgers
Advantage	Michigan State opens with Toledo and Eastern Michigan at home and gets a bye immediately before the late Michigan/Washington/Oregon stretch.
Expected	4.6 wins · most likely 5-7
Floor / ceiling	3-9 / 7-5

9. Betting Lens

Angle	Read
Market posture	HC Pat Fitzgerald gives the rebuild a clearer long-term structure, but that should not be confused with an immediate bowl floor: No. 95 returning production, low continuity and the late Michigan/Washington/Oregon run still cap Year 1.
Back them when	The price respects turnover and RB Cam Edwards plus the OL can keep QB Alessio Milivojevic out of obvious passing downs.
Fade/pass when	Pressure-heavy defenses or efficient passing teams can attack the unsettled OL and rebuilt secondary.
Key monitor	Final OL five, WR order, WR Rodney Bullard Jr. eligibility, secondary rotation, kicker/P Rhys Dakin transition, defensive havoc
Week 1 baseline	vs. Toledo: rating-only fair baseline Michigan State –13.0 ; compare with the live market before betting. Live market: Michigan State –10.5 (CBS Sports, Aug. 25).

10. Summary

Michigan State has clearer structure at QB and RB under OC Nick Sheridan, with QB Alessio Milivojevic established and RB Cam Edwards adding proven production. DC Joe Rossi retains useful anchors, but the roster is still rebuilding at WR, OL, the front and secondary.

Five wins is the safer baseline because returning production is only No. 95 and the schedule is hard. A real rebound requires the OL to reduce havoc and the rebuilt defense to improve its down-to-down efficiency.

About this primer

DRWhittier · cfb.drwhittier.com · X: [@GatorBait7](https://twitter.com/GatorBait7) · Version 1.0 - August 25, 2026

© 2026 DRWhittier. Original analysis, commentary, selection, and arrangement.

Sources: [2026 roster](#) · [coaching](#) · [fall camp](#) · [NFL departures](#) · [Preseason Camp Preview Defense and](#) · [Preseason Camp Update Catching Up](#) · [Preseason Camp Update Pat Fitzgerald](#) · [Pat Fitzgerald Returns to the](#)

Last updated: August 25, 2026